

DEBATING MICHAEL CALVIN McGEE'S "CRITICAL" SHIFT IN RHETORICAL THEORY.

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Abstract: This essay stages a debate between two different theories of Michael Calvin McGee: ideographs (1980) and discourse fragments (1990). Examining the rhetoric of equality in Peter Singer's Animal Liberation, it is argued that McGee's three structural relationships for recomposing textual fragments provide a strong starting point for scholarly investigation, but does not provide an account of rhetorical motive. As an alternative, this essay argues for a new concept, the "ideographic fragment," which explains the desire to make value appeals in a culture lacking stable social narratives.

On April 24, 2007, The Daily Show with Jon Stewart produced a "presidential" debate over U.S. foreign policy in Iraq. Splicing together publically accessible video footage, Jon Stewart moderated a heated exchange between President Bush in his first term and the President in his second term. The juxtaposition of video clips, recorded from the same person yet espousing totally contradictory views, accentuated drastic changes in a supposedly consistent foreign policy. A section toward the end of the debate was particularly insightful:

Jon Stewart: Alright, look, look, we're not getting anywhere here. Let's back up. First term President Bush, why did we invade Iraq in the first place?

Old Bush: The terrorist threat to America and the world will be diminished the moment that Saddam Hussein is disarmed.

Jon Stewart: I see, so you wanted to protect America from the terrorist threat. Current President Bush, why can't we leave Iraq?

New Bush: Our enemies would have a safe haven from which to plan and launch attacks on the American people. [Long pause with restrained laughter]

Jon Stewart: So let me see if I have this straight. Basically, first term President Bush, you invaded to remove the threat of Saddam Hussein, and you current President Bush are there to battle the threat created by the lack of Saddam Hussein. [Laughter and Applause] Hmm, ok. That's interesting. So, basically, second term President Bush has to undo the damage created by first term President Bush. First term President Bush, any thoughts as you watch your future self prosecute this second part of the war?

Old Bush: This looks like the re-run of a bad movie and I'm not interested in watching it. [Laughter]

Jon Stewart: Wise words. (Jeverbaum & Stewart, 2007)

Of course, one could create rationalizations to ease the tensions between the "Bushes." One could claim that the extent of the internal Iraqi power struggle after toppling the regime was not properly anticipated, that Saddam Hussein was only one of many targets in the "War on Terror," or, for the more cynical, that the positions of both old and new Bush are designed to mask a consistent foreign policy based on the economic interests of military and energy companies. Regardless of the possible rationalizations, this debate, pitting the views of the same person against themselves at two different moments in juxtaposition, still seems unsettling. It confronts us with the fear that convictions can change radically over a short period of time and that the work of others cannot always be trusted as a stable resource for argument.

For rhetorical critics and theorists, the shift in Michael Calvin McGee's work from ideological criticism (1980) to his later concern for discourse fragments circulating in a postmodern culture (1990) seems to have a similar effect. Stuck between two seemingly incompatible genres of rhetorical criticism, scholars

have produced a series of rationalizations that have prevented a debate between the two “McGees” from being staged. One of the most common responses has been to ignore the fragmentation thesis (McGee, 1990) and to continue to use the ideograph (McGee, 1980) as a tool of rhetorical analysis (Cloud, 1998; Delgado, 1999; Moore, 1993; 1994; 1996; Short, 1994). Another set of studies has used the later McGee (1990) to analyze the disintegration of meta-narratives into visual memory fragments that support post-Cold War consumer culture (Dickenson, 1997; Taylor, 2003). Some have attempted to simply fuse the notion of “performance fragments” with ideological critique, arguing that sound bite culture serves a dominant ideology (Erickson, 2000), allowing the powerful to stitch fragments together that rationalize institutional authority (Hasain, 1997). Finally, those that acknowledge the “postmodern turn” in McGee’s criticism have found it to be a source of anxiety (Goodnight, 1995) or a threat to a materially interested rhetoric (Cloud, 1994; Condit, 1990).

Judging by the various reactions of critics appropriating the ideas of both the earlier (1980) and the later (1990) McGee, the tension between them creates a theoretical quandary for critics. Is it even possible to resolve their inherent divisions? Which McGee should be privileged in the discussion? How can one develop a bridge between the two theories (if at all)? Perhaps instead of trying to hide the disciplinary anxiety of incommensurable opinions expressed by the same scholar, rhetoricians ought to take a cue from *The Daily Show*. In much the same way that the “Bushes” were made to debate one another through selective video editing, the tension between the earlier McGee’s commitment to ideological criticism (1980) and the later McGee’s challenge to the possibility of an all-encompassing social totality in the form of audience constructed discourse fragments (1990) ought to be subjected to a similar juxtaposition. The debate form, as a mechanism that distills and highlights differences between positions, however minute, offers a way to clarify these different “rhetorical genres” and to begin the process of negotiating between them.

In order to create a space of encounter between the perspectives of the ideological McGee (1980) and the postmodern, fragmentary McGee (1990), it is necessary to provide a practical medium for theoretical application. *Animal Liberation* (2002), written by famed ethicist Peter Singer, offers a conduit for dialogue because “equality” rhetoric, explicitly identified by McGee (1980) as a significant ideograph in American culture, is a central part of Singer’s rhetorical appeal in *Animal Liberation*. Originally published in 1975, *Animal Liberation* received critical acclaim as the seminal text of the modern animal rights movement (Birnbaum, 2003). In philosophy, the text revived a discussion on the nature of rights as either linguistic markers used to express suffering (Singer, 2002) or as ethical absolutes (Regan, 1984). A considerable amount of literature has recently emerged applying Singer’s equality principle to the legal protection of animals (Bartlett, 2002; Decoste, 2003; Kniaz, 1995; Letourneau, 2003; St. Pierre, 1998; Sunstein, 2003; Wise, 2002). Even negative responses to the work of Singer acknowledge the importance of his vision of equality to the conversation concerning the moral status of animals (Coope, 2003; Lloyd, 2004; Saunders, 2003). Much like the space of a popular comedic news program, Singer’s use of equality has sufficient circulation in American culture to function as a reasonable test case for these different genres of criticism.

To preview, I suggest that the three structural relationships for reconstructing texts from fragments, outlined by the later McGee (1990), provide a strong way to catalogue shifts in meaning, audience appropriations, and the textual responsiveness of fragments operating in a culture. However, they are unable to provide a theory of value that can account for the popularity of certain fragments at a particular point in time. To do so, one needs to transform the ideograph from a linguistic indication of a dominant culture’s power to manipulate the consciousness of society (Cloud, 1998) to an appeal generated by the desire to reconstitute a single vision of society in the face of growing

fragmentation (Biesecker, 2002; Bhabha, 1994), which I call the “ideographic fragment.” This conceptual shift parallels the theoretical development of the public sphere from a unified field of civil society’s deliberation (Habermas, 1989) to a divided and contentious conglomeration of publics with only relative amounts of cultural influence (Hauser, 1999; Warner, 2002).

To make this debate happen, I first outline the dispute between the earlier (1980) and later (1990) McGee. Second, an analysis of *Animal Liberation* and the rhetoric of equality occur using the protocols for textual interpretation appropriate to McGee’s (1980) ideographic criticism. Third, McGee’s (1990) directives for textual construction in a fragmented culture are applied to *Animal Liberation*’s use of equality. Fourth, I argue that the fragmentation thesis elides an account of the intensity of social influence, answered through the redefinition of ideograph as “ideographic fragment.” The conclusion comments on the significance of this study and makes suggestions for future research.

The Stage of the Debate

Ernst Wraga’s “Public address: A study in social and intellectual history” (1947) marks a revolutionary moment in rhetorical criticism. Neo-Aristotelian criticism had, up to that point, emphasized the importance of the immediate context and audience (Wichelns, 1925), overlooking a broader audience and the long-term influences of rhetoric (Black, 1978). Wraga displaces the immediate influence of the speaker in favor of the relationship between a text and the transmission of important ideas in a culture. In short, rhetoric was beginning to be theorized as a social force in history, not just as targeted to persuade an immediate audience.

Michael Calvin McGee’s seminal essay “The ‘ideograph’: The link between rhetoric and ideology” (1980) develops a method to examine the long-term ideational impact of rhetoric, while taking issue with some of the central tenets of Wraga (1947). Rather than conceiving of

the social force of rhetoric through the transmission of a determinate message (or content), McGee sees persuasive force operating through rhetorical appeals to high level concepts, or ideographs, which are empty of specific meaning while being heavily overdetermined in society. By tracing the diachronic (the plurality of the concept's meanings over time) and synchronic (its relationship to other important concepts at a particular moment in time) structures of ideographs, one can come close to knowing how ideology operates in a particular culture at a certain moment in time. Following Althusser (2001), McGee believes that ideology is the key concept for understanding the reproduction of the means of production, "the trick-of-the-mind which deludes us into believing that we 'think' with/through/for a 'society' to which we 'belong'" (1980, p. 4). In this way he links the idealist study of myths and ideas to a materialist account of the modes of production.

Published a decade later, McGee's "Text, context, and the fragmentation of contemporary culture" (1990) breaks sharply from his earlier work on ideographs (1980). Tracing the 20th century emergence of rhetoric in very broad strokes, he characterizes most of the rhetorical tradition as fixated on criticism. Rhetoric was treated as a type or genre of discourse, different from poems, novels, and theatre. As a result, the discipline largely assumed the existence of a text, which is separable from context, as a stable artifact for criticism. McGee (1990) reverses the traditional moniker of "rhetorical criticism," arguing for a "critical rhetoric" that focuses on discourse as a "performance" (1990, p. 279).¹

¹ His advocacy comes on the heels of Raymie McKerrow's (1989) call for a critical rhetoric. Though many of the conclusions are the same, these two thinkers call for a critical rhetoric based on very different grounds. For McKerrow, a critical rhetoric must be a materially invested, yet self-reflexive enterprise that criticizes the techniques of domination enabled by particular rhetorical strategies. Although he recognizes knowledge as "doxastic," or socially constituted, McKerrow's deployment of Michel Foucault's theory of power still largely assumes a set of stable institutional forces of hegemony that can be identified, criticized, and displaced by the

Rather than assuming the existence of a completed text, critical rhetoric posits that:

Texts are to be understood to be larger than the apparently finished discourse that presents itself as transparent. The apparently finished discourse is in fact a dense reconstruction of all the bits of other discourses from which it was made. It is fashioned from what we can call ‘fragments.’ (1990, p. 279)

The task of the critic involves constructing a text from available bits of discourse, making “a text suitable for criticism” (1990, p. 288).

Although both theories stem from the same general assumption that texts are a social force in a culture, several points of contention emerge between the two decade-inaugurating essays of Michael Calvin McGee (1980, 1990). The first point concerns the nature of the worlds theorized by each work. With the ideograph, McGee (1980) argues for a method to understand the ideology of contemporary society. Concerned with the structures guiding one’s life, the piece suggests that understanding the operation of ideographs allows the critic to know how ideology constructs subject positions and controls populations. Myths are not just symbolic resources for the world making practices of humans, but tools of securing certain narratives of structural inequality.

Following Lyotard’s declaration of the end of meta-narratives (1984) and the crumbling edifice of Cold-War

politically motivated critic. His appropriation of Foucault has been highly criticized by Biesecker (1992) and Greene (1998) for presuming an oppositional relationship between domination and resistance that Foucault’s writings seem to question explicitly. In McGee’s version of critical rhetoric, no such notions of power, hegemony, and resistance are foregrounded as important in the process of textual construction. While I share the skepticism of others regarding McKerrow’s appropriation of Foucault, McGee’s unwillingness to address the question of power directly is a stunning omission. It plays a major part in the need to reconcile ideographic criticism with the postmodern condition in the final section of this essay.

structures (Bleiker, 2000), McGee writes the move to “critical rhetoric” in the face of the fragmentation of contemporary culture (1990). No longer tied to a belief in the totality of a social structure (ideology), the postmodern condition refuses the possibility that a “consensus...could embrace the totality of metaprescriptions regulating the totality of statements circulating in the social collectivity” (Lyotard, 1984, p. 65). McGee (1990) argues the fragmentation of contemporary culture also fragments the text. No longer a unified whole, all that seems to reach people are “discursive fragments of context” (p. 287). Rather than texts providing a vehicle for conditioning populations to accept prevailing modes of production, all narratives of social cohesion are contestable and questionable. In the era of post-modernity, “the public’s business is now being done more often via television spots, documentaries, mass entertainment, and ‘quotable quotes’ on the evening news” (p. 286). In short, the fragmentation thesis questions the primacy of ideographs as the rhetorical building blocks of the Ideological State Apparatus (Althusser, 2001). Whereas McGee (1980) would read Singer’s text as a deployment of pre-existing ideological resources that ultimately sustain inequitable power relationships, McGee (1990) would see Singer’s definition of equality as a fragment of discourse appropriated from previous sources, but capable of being continually ventriloquized by future audiences for their own ends.

Second, McGee (1980) argues that rhetorical critics need to analyze two structural relationships in order to understand the ideograph’s link to ideology: diachronic and synchronic movement. Diachronic movement consists of the shifts in meanings of the ideograph available to the present situation, which functionally means the totality of all previous meanings conferred upon a particular ideograph over time. Synchronic movement is the relationship between the ideograph under consideration and the other ideographs operating in society. For example, if trying to understand the

ideograph of “equality,” one would trace the historical uses of the term, along with how it relates to other significant value appeals, such as “liberty,” “freedom,” and “justice.” In Singer’s case, equality is a value driven by the need to calculate positive and negative impacts, offering a mechanism to maximize the collective “interests” of society.

A decade later, McGee (1990) suggests that the critic textualizes a fragment through an attention to three structural relationships: sources, culture, and influence. Sources (relevant previous meanings from which the rhetor forms the fragment) and culture (relevant social circumstances in which a fragment emerges) seem to collectively express the same critical concerns as tracing diachronic and synchronic movement, respectively. However, the third structural relationship, influence, questions the causal link between ideograph and audience compliance assumed in the early McGee (1980). In other words, for the ideological McGee (1980), “the rhetorical process becomes implicated in an act of social conditioning likely to promote asymmetrical relations of power favorable to the speaker” (Greene, 1998, p. 23). For the postmodern McGee (1990), the fragment gains attention through its cultural prominence (circulation and repetition). Overall, the relationships relevant for text interpretation (1980) and text construction (1990) are fairly similar, with some modifications regarding the nature of rhetorical effect.²

² It is difficult to parse the difference in rhetorical effect in the earlier and later McGee, but it is important for understanding how a text/fragment is related to its cultural influence. Giving form to a materialist theory of rhetoric, McGee (1982) defines it as “a natural social phenomenon in the context of which symbolic claims are made on the behavior and/or belief of one or more persons, allegedly in the interest of such individuals, and with a strong presumption that such claims will cause meaningful change” (p. 38). The success or failure of rhetoric is assessed based on the ability connect the desired change to the speaker’s action, which makes this version of influence a direct cause and effect chain between speech act and outcome. For the later McGee (1990), the notion of influence softens, instead designating the ability of a fragment to receive attention from other textual fragments circulating in the culture. The measure of success

These two differences provide a broad conceptual map that can be used to ascertain the distance between the ideological McGee (1980) and the postmodern McGee (1990). In the next two sections, these differences are operationalized with respect to Peter Singer's use of equality rhetoric in *Animal Liberation* (2002).

Equality as Ideograph

Ideographic criticism, inaugurated by the earlier McGee (1980), supplies the largest area of work in communication studies on the history of the rhetoric of equality. In his introductory essay, the term equality is used as an example of an ideograph's capacity to define a collectivity:

So, in the United States, we claim a common belief in "equality," as do citizens of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics [USSR]; but "equality" is not the same word in its meaning or its usage. One can therefore precisely define the difference between the two communities, in part, by comparing the usage of definitive ideographs. (p. 8)

This gesture for studying comparative ideology is a product of studying each culture's synchronic affiliations of equality. Presumably, one could read the "Cold War" political conflict between "democracy" and "communism" through these different constellations. For instance, one might find that the political usage of equality in the former USSR is linked to their theorization of material conditions: it offers a moral principle to assess the proper outcome of state policies. To say that all persons are equal is factual; they are entitled to similar wages, living conditions, and proportions of collective labor.

is not compliance, but citation, whether that occurs in assent, response, or extension of a fragment's meaning. As such, McGee's (1990) view of influence more closely corresponds to contemporary demands to follow a more nuanced logic of "articulation" (Biesecker, 1989; Greene, 1998; Stormer, 2004).

Peter Singer's equality principle in *Animal Liberation* is most certainly a product of the intellectual tradition of West European and American social philosophy. Defining equality as "the equal consideration of equal interests" seems tautological, but his expression gains meaning if one has a strong grasp of its context of usage and its contrast with the "factual" equality characteristic of communist value constellations:

The extension of the basic principle of equality from one group to another does not imply that we must treat both groups in exactly the same way, or grant exactly the same rights to both groups. The basic principle of equality does not require equal or identical treatment; it requires equal consideration. Equal consideration for different beings may lead to different treatment and different rights. (Singer, 2002, p. 2)

Singer's rhetorical gesture in this passage has an important ideological function. By separating his explanation of equality from one that drives communist doctrine, Singer attempts to display moderation and to garner support for his principle (the text is written in 1975 at the height of the Cold War). He becomes even more suggestive on this point, arguing that his version of equality emerges not only in the work of Jeremy Bentham, but also in "Thomas Jefferson, who was responsible for writing the principle of the equality of men into the American Declaration of Independence" (p. 5).

Furthermore, Singer (2002) uses the extension of rights to women and to African Americans as a rhetorical resource for extending protections to non-human animals, a goal that only makes sense if the term "equality" is placed in a value constellation with other common ideographs such as "liberty," "freedom," and personal "interests." Arguing that the protections of these groups are not rationalized on the basis of equitable ability or needs in all human beings, but rather based upon the need to consider the different interests

of others when formulating personal or social policy, Singer explains the relationship between the principle of equality and the protection of these other values:

Concern for the well-being of children growing up in America would require that we teach them to read; concern for the well-being of pigs may require no more than that we leave them with other pigs in a place where there is adequate food and room to run freely. But the basic element—the taking into account of the interests of the being, whatever those interests may be—must, according to the principle of equality, be extended to all beings, black or white, masculine or feminine, human or nonhuman. (p. 5)

For Singer, it seems obvious that human children have a personal “interest” in scholastic enrichment, while pigs, lacking the linguistic capacity to articulate desires, want to be left alone to their own devices, paralleling the traditional invocation of “liberty” as a form of self-determination. In each case, equality relates to these other values as a principle of calculation: to compare interests fairly and to make decisions that aid the satisfaction of the most quality interests when tradeoffs exist.

Singer’s use of equality is indebted to previous historical usage of the term (diachronic association) in the Western philosophical and political tradition. According to McGee (1980), “earlier usages become precedent, touchstones for judging the propriety of the ideograph in a current circumstance. The meaning of ‘equality’ does not rigidify because situations seeming to require its usage are never perfectly similar: as the situations vary, so the meaning of ‘equality’ expands and contracts” (p. 10). In one of the most thorough studies of the diachronic associations of equality in American culture, Condit and Lucaites (1993) suggest that the possible meanings of equality exploded from the 1820s to the 1980s, largely due to the prowess of African American rhetors. In the immediate context in which Peter Singer’s *Animal Liberation* occurs (mid 1970s), two

discourses of equality coexist concerning race relations in the United States: the “integrationist” call for equitable treatment under the law and for equitable opportunity for personal development, and the “cultural separationist posture” that called “for a combination of absolute economic equality and absolute cultural equality” (Condit & Lucaites, 1993, p. 207).

Singer’s equality principle can be read as a conservative reaction to the explosion of equality rhetoric in the early 1970s that challenged the pervasive racism and sexism of American culture. Singer uses the rhetorical resources of both these movements consistently in his appeal to protect non-human animals, yet he curiously refuses to apply his thinking to other issues without the same level of cultural cache (e.g. discourses concerning societal heterosexism). The manifestation of this implicitly conservative argumentative appeal comes from the co-presence of two characteristics in his work. First, he works very hard to court the mainstream anti-racist and anti-sexist sentiments of progressives by drawing parallels between the commitments of each movement. For example:

Racists violate the principle of equality by giving greater weight to the interests of their own race when there is a clash between their interests and the interests of those of another race. Sexists violate the principle of equality by favoring the interests of their own sex. Similarly, speciesists allow the interests of their own species to override the greater interests of members of other species. The pattern is identical in each case. (2002, p. 9)

Second, while courting these other groups, he also chastises those that push the extremes of factual economic equality. By formulating equality as a principle for deliberating across interests, Singer refers back to the philosophical formulation of the term popular in the late Eighteenth and early Nineteenth centuries. His traditional notion relied on, “fairness in terms of a prior moral code that entailed

rankings and necessitated appropriate actions with regards to them” (Condit & Lucaites, 1993, p. 29), against a more expansive definition. While in one sense such a gesture is done to increase the persuasive appeal for non-human protection, it also does so at the expense of other progressive social forces.

I have tried to offer a broad outline of how McGee’s (1980) theory of ideographs could be applied to Peter Singer’s *Animal Liberation* (2002). Of course, one could provide more details about the synchronic and diachronic associations at work in Singer’s invocation of equality rhetoric. One thing seems certain even from this brief experiment in McGee’s interpretive method: the goal of ideographic criticism is to provide a thick description of a term’s use at a particular moment in time by reading its cultural context. In doing so, one explains why the speaker deploys a particular ideological resource rather than others, and what effect the speaker desires.

This centrality of motive in speech production becomes a key point of contrast between the ideographic (1980) and the postmodern (1990) McGee, as the next section illustrates. How would the elder McGee (1990) analyze equality discourse as a fragment? Do his three structural relationships offer a fruitful avenue for subtle textual construction? Going further into *Animal Liberation* and its significance in contemporary culture, the following section outlines the bare essentials of the three structural relationships for text construction in order to clarify the differences dividing the two generations of McGees and to test the validity of the latter’s method.

Equality as Fragment

A number of changes have occurred in the rhetorical canon since McGee’s (1980) attempt to reconcile rhetoric and the study of ideology. The originator of ideographic criticism seems to shift his critical perspective later in life, arguing for the fragmentation of the text (1990). On face,

McGee's later work seems to directly respond to his previous theory of ideographs, rendering it anachronistic. How would a scholar making a modest attempt to follow the directives of text construction provided by McGee (1990) read Singer's principle of equality? I divide these reflections according to the three structural relationships that the postmodern McGee (1990) outlines as significant for textual construction in order to provide a clear picture of the methodological contrasts that dominate these two decade inaugurating essays.

Discourse and Sources

Negotiating several distinct forms of utilitarianism, Peter Singer fuses the thought of Bentham, Darwin, Mill, Hare, and others. Singer, an outspoken advocate of utilitarianism,³ posits that the fundamental principle of utilitarian thinking is the principle of equality, formulated as the equal consideration of equal interests (2002). He explains: "No matter what the nature of the being, the principle of equality requires that its suffering be counted equally with the like suffering—insofar as rough comparisons can be made—of any other being" (2002, p. 8). This guiding principle is derived from references to Jeremy Bentham's utilitarianism which values pleasure and pain above all else. "The question is not, Can they reason? nor Can they talk? but, Can they suffer?" (Bentham, as quoted in Singer, 2002, p. 7). Rather than follow Bentham's prescription that suffering (or pain) is the only moral consideration, Singer recognizes a diverse group of interests, with some allotted more value consideration than others

³ Utilitarianism is generally understood as an ethical framework that attempts to achieve the greatest good for society in any given situation. This axiom, on its own, only provides a general framework for calculation. The meaning of "good" in the context of utilitarian thinking has been the source of debate for nearly 200 years. Rather than summarize that debate, I wish only to attend to the construction of utilitarianism that Peter Singer produces by stringing together the fragments of thought provided by his forerunners. As such, for the purposes of this essay, utilitarianism will be operationally defined by Peter Singer's commentary.

(Mill, 2003). Intellectual virtues carry more importance when in direct conflict with pain unless a substantial asymmetry of intensity exists in favor of pain (Singer, 2001).

R. M. Hare (1981) suggests that moral thinking is an imaginative act of understanding the interests of another. One can understand another's pain only by observing outward expressions that seem to be analogous to one's own pain. Singer uses the concept of reading one's own aversion to pain into the responses of another for two purposes: to articulate similarity of response to stimuli between humans and animals as grounds to presume the existence of pain in animals, and to universalize the principle of caring for the interests of another as the goal of moral philosophy. Humans, according to Singer, strive morally to take the "point of view of the universe" (2001, p. 268) by seeing beyond the limited perspective of the solipsistic individual. Thus, the construction of utilitarianism mapped out by Singer reveals itself as a radical selflessness produced from universalizing self-interested decision making (1993).

Singer parts ways with Mill (2003) and Hare (1981) on the narrative that grounds moral consideration. Rather than ascribe an abstract or transcendental value to reason, Singer lays the foundation for valuing interests in evolutionary biology (2000). The complexity of an organism's self-awareness dictates the quality of its interests. The more complex the organism becomes, the more developed and intensified its interests will be. From this principle, one can argue that, when in conflict, one ought to choose the value of a fully developed human being over the suffering of a dog, or other lower order animal (Singer, 2002). McGee (1990) suggests that discourses do not emerge *ex nihilo*, but rather from a dense web of competing interpretations. Though Singer speaks to the popular, tracing the sources of discourse reveals the complicated terrain of philosophical citation within the utilitarian tradition.

Discourse and Culture

With the collapse of context as a separable and objective entity, one must account for the responsiveness of a textual fragment to its cultural surroundings (McGee, 1990). As a number of scholars note, Singer's defense of non-human animals also responds to other constructions of equality circulating in the public sphere (Brennan, 2003; Coope, 2003; Hari, 2004; Herrnstein Smith, 2004; Kenny, 2003; Regan, 1984; Singer, 1986; 2002). In the previous account of equality as ideograph, I already documented some of the conservative inclinations of this discourse. On the other hand, thinking about his equality principle as a circulating "fragment" in a culture that is not determined by reference to an ideological field, a conservative response also has libratory possibilities.

Singer (2002) criticizes certain strands of Civil Rights discourse for appealing to factual equality. Rhetorical scholars have confirmed Singer's observations about the prevalence of this particular strain of discourse (Condit & Lucaites, 1993; Hasain Jr. & Klinger, 2002; Haskins, 1981). Singer attempts to reveal some of the undesirable consequences of this position through two arguments: the inherent inequality of human beings and the risks of statistical analyses of race and gender. The first argument suggests that differences in character and ability are essential to the uniqueness of each human being (the principle of individuality undergirding nearly all rights claims), denying the possibility of ever truly being equal. The second is a variation of the first, but argues that statistical data on the aggregate characteristics of a race could be used as a basis for discrimination (Singer, 2002).

To compensate, Singer argues that framing equality as a moral principle does not risk biological essentialism of both humans and non-humans or the inequitable treatment of others. He explains that "precisely what our concern or consideration requires us to do may vary according to the characteristics of those affected by what we do" (2002, p. 5).

The principle of equal consideration is a moral doctrine necessitated by the need to fulfill and negotiate between interests. The qualities of each individual being matter, but not the typology of that being. In the cultural milieu of 1970s America, Singer's appeal seems, in one sense, to upend the Afrocentric discourses of equality identified by Condit and Lucaites (1993), suggesting, in a fashion akin to political conservatism, that positions advancing factual equality support the cause of racial discrimination. But in another sense, one can clearly differentiate the motive of his injunction; he argues instead that Civil Rights discourses would do well to insulate themselves from being assaulted by scientific developments and pseudo-eugenic discourses. By accepting his version of the equality principle, one does not give up a struggle for equitable treatment, but that defense must be based on the development of certain human interests and with attention to possible negative outcomes.

As an analysis of the relationship between the fragment and its culture demonstrates, the emergence of equality rhetoric in *Animal Liberation* (2002) is not only indebted to the philosophical thinking of previous generations, but is also responsive to other uses of equality circulating in society. Rather than this response simply offering an ideological return to an older (predominately white) meaning, Singer is able to frame the concept as potentially useful to Civil Rights groups, if effectively deployed. The ambivalence between the conservative and the libratory possibilities of the fragment requires that one attend more closely to a third structural relationship in the postmodern McGee (1990), entirely missing from the ideological McGee (1980), that considers the subsequent reception and appropriation of the fragment.

Discourse and Influence

McGee uses the concept of influence to capture the radical intertextuality of any given discourse. Fragments that matter will be remembered and "structured into our

experience” (1990, p. 282). This postmodern McGee (1990) parts with his earlier work on ideology (1980), at least in part, by refusing the possibility of ever knowing the totality of a given situation, context, or linguistic concept. Rather than the ideograph representing dominant social interests, a fragment begs to be engaged, denied, or transformed (1990). Not only do fragments respond to a particular situation in a culture, but they are also responded to and engaged by other discourses.

In the philosophical discipline, Tom Regan (1984) produced one of the most well known responses to Singer. Regan argues that utilitarian thinking, regardless of its strain, fails to provide adequate protection for animals, largely due to its rejection of rights claims. In any given situation, Singer still allows for the killing of non-human animals, so long as human interests outweigh animal interests. The real danger becomes that humans, who have self-interests, will just routinely value their interests above another being. In response, Regan articulates a Neo-Kantian view of rights, positing that the characteristic of sentience is sufficient to have a natural right to bodily integrity. Regan devotes much of his book to proving the sentience of most non-human animals. Finally, he argues for a principle of presumption against taking the life of another, so long as there remains reasonable doubt of an animal’s object status. Regan, responding to the dangerous, relative nature of Singer’s concept of “interests,” makes an appeal for the equal treatment of animals based on the factual existence of sentience.

In the pragmatic battleground of the courtroom, Singer’s principle of equality has taken on a life of its own. In Canadian law, there has been a huge debate regarding the treatment of animals in anti-cruelty legislation (Wise, 2002). In this case, the Darwinian underpinnings of Singer’s argument become a mechanism to erase the distinct barrier between subjects (humans) and objects (animals). Instead, animal development exists somewhere along the continuum

of evolutionary progression. Though some have attempted to think of rights as an absolute category (Decoste, 2003 arguing for animal exclusion, and Bartlett, 2002; Letourneau, 2003 arguing for inclusion), the rhetoric of Darwinism infused with the principle of equality seems to mediate conservative concerns and radical politics, opening a dialogue for progressive change (Rachels, 1998).

Singer's philosophy can also be re-composed to serve conservative political interests. First, an objection is raised regarding Singer's willingness, in subsequent writings, to defend disposing of humans with intellectual disabilities (Vehmas, 1999). Once he admits to the differentiation of interests, then those humans that have not been able to develop higher level cognitive capacities are assigned lower value interests in comparison to others. Second, Singer's position also risks the reduction of all diverse characteristics of beings to an exchange value couched in the vague language of interests, reducing the multiplicity of worldly experience to a flat, dedifferentiated and overly simplistic world view (Herrnstein Smith, 2004). Third, even McGee (1987) cautioned about the association of equality in the United States with property and equal opportunity, both of which can easily be used to discriminate against those with no such interests. According to that view, we can dominate the environment and own property at will because animals have no "interest" in property.

These examples demonstrate the ambivalence of influence for a fragment. Framed as a piecemeal protection, a mechanism to make large-scale progressive changes, or as a way to rollback protections of vulnerable populations, the reception of Singer's equality rhetoric seems to confirm McGee's (1990) observation that fragments are embedded in several different contexts of experience. In this small sample, the fragment circulates between philosophical reflection, legal frameworks, and social concerns in popular culture. It is precisely this aspect of a fragment (its ability to insinuate itself in a multitude of different contexts) that

requires a de-emphasis on the intent of the speaker in favor of tracing multiple, often contradictory, effects of discourse. Although clearly advantageous in this regard, one must still ask: is anything lost in the analysis? This last question ought to drive researchers toward reconsidering ideographic analysis.

From “Ideograph” to “Ideographic Fragment”

A clear advantage of the method articulated by the postmodern McGee (1990), critics trace the processes of transformation through clashes and convergences between fragments, which help to produce a text. Following the sources, the culture, and the influence that structure the emergence of Singer’s equality fragment provides a sophisticated object of criticism. In explaining how a fragment transforms into text, another set of questions surface for the postmodern McGee (1990): Why do some fragments have a higher degree of circulation than others? What accounts for the intensity of influence of fragments?

Now the trend of the debate reverses with the younger, ideographic McGee (1980) reminding the older (1990) of an important element for understanding how rhetoric works in particular situations. McGee’s (1980) theory of ideographs clearly had the advantage of explaining the relationship between a particular value appeal and the reproduction of a mode of production. The desire to maintain relations of production that sustain asymmetrical social positions offered a simple, but important, motive for producing rhetoric. But the lack of a stable meta-narrative and value system in a postmodern society makes it impossible to understand why certain appeals occur. Given the dissolution of any grounding narrative that would motivate such an action, how would one explain why Peter Singer uses equality rhetoric in order to protect non-human animals? Why do people feel compelled to respond to his appeal?

In order to venture an answer, one must return to one of the sources of inspiration for McGee's (1990) fragmentation thesis. According to Lyotard, the postmodern condition does admit that proponents of ideology exist and attempt to regulate collective behavior, but "it is the absence for which the ideology of the 'system,' with its pretensions to totality, tries to compensate and which it expresses in the cynicism of its criterion for performance" (1984, p. 65). Biesecker (2002) provides a concrete example for this phenomenon. Discussing the resurgence of a national memory of World War II, she writes:

Thus, prompted by the unprecedented decision to break ground between the Washington Monument and the Lincoln Memorial for a structure commemorating not just the veterans of WWII but also an exemplary era of "American national unity," this examination of several contemporary WWII texts argues that the return of WWII may be understood as a more or less thinly veiled conservative response to the contemporary crisis of national identity. (p. 406)

Biesecker's rationale that the need to commemorate an era of "national unity" is responsive to the perceived fragmentation of citizen identity mirrors Lyotard's suggestion that ideological claims are a product of dissensus, not consensus. In other words, the only reason to talk about and commemorate a national unity is because it does not exist and likely never existed as a material fact (Bhabba, 1994). The speaker, attempting to cope with the mass of confusion, the contradictory tendencies, and the seeming lack of direction exhibited in the actions of contemporary society, uses the speaking occasion to stitch together a coherent social narrative from the fragments of text circulating in a culture.

Thinking briefly about Singer's (2002) formulation of the moral principle of equality, these supplementary theoretical materials allow the critic to piece together a

plausible motive for the fragment's emergence. The intense struggle over equality in the Civil Rights movement (Condit & Lucaites, 1993; Hasain & Klinger, 2002), its codification into law (Zarefsky, 1980), and the attempt of the Women's Movement to pass certain equal rights protections (Foss, 1979), left the American nation with an incoherent amalgam of different usages of equality in contention with one another, from the legal securing of opportunity, to appeals for equitable outcomes, and even to attempts to justify continued inequalities. Singer attempts to suture the social divisions driven by the different definition of these terms, appealing to it as moral principle rather than as a statement of factual similarity or as an inherent characteristic of each individual. As my account in the previous section of the "influences" of Singer's fragment testifies, his view of equality has had a myriad of different rhetorical effects, ranging from affirmation, to the limited reformation of the legal sphere, and even to its repudiation by other scholars.

Though ideology may never reach total control nor bind the entirety of the social field, the remnants of meta-narrative construction (much like the broken pieces of the Berlin Wall), still seem to have appeal in a fragmented culture. No longer akin to "God" terms (McGee, 1980) concepts formerly considered to have an ideographic function serve as a medium of exchange between speaking subjects. Their respective familiarity with certain terms and conditioned respect for a term's value (though empty in itself) creates a magnetic relationship between the "ideographic fragment" and other fragments circulating in the culture. The "ideographic fragment" operates like a sound bite, its influence no longer determined by the truth it posits, but instead performed through its repetition or iteration (Derrida, 1988). The path of least resistance: gain attention in popular culture by attaching to something familiar and desired, then attempt to mutate the significance of the term, changing its association with other fragments.

The fragmentation of culture and the types of rhetorical appeals characteristic to it have a parallel theoretical analog in the conversation concerning the nature of the “public sphere.” In response to the desire to recuperate a late 18th and early 19th century version of the public sphere, understood as “the rational communication of a public consisting of cultivated human beings” (Habermas, 1989, p. 35), Lyotard (1984) argues that the fragmentation of culture frustrates any attempt to resurrect a universal, rational consensus; it “destroys a belief that still underlies Habermas’s research” (p. 66). As social divisions in contemporary culture proliferate, it becomes necessary to theorize the internal division of the public sphere. Michael Warner (2002), in an attempt to increase the visibility of particular marginalized groups in American culture, theorizes the element of the public with the concept of a counterpublic: a public that is in “tension with a larger public... [and that] maintains at some level, conscious or not, an awareness of its subordinate status” (p. 56). While Warner’s gesture goes a long way to develop an analytic framework for studying cultural fragmentation, the notion of the counterpublic still presumes the existence of a dominant public with a relatively stable ideology. Instead, we ought to follow Hauser’s (1999) theorization of multiple, vernacular publics: temporary social groups brought together over a common concern, and that compete with several other public discourses for increased cultural attention. “Ideographic fragments” are the products of a dispersed, multiplicitous public sphere containing a cacophony of vernacular voices: they strive for social cohesion, but in relation to voices of conceptual extension, conceptual distinction, and outright dissent. They have only relative degrees of rhetorical success, largely measured by the extent to which such fragments are given reference by other contemporaneous voices in a culture. As “ideographic fragment,” Singer’s proscription has made some inroads into changing the tenor of the animal protection conversation, but has failed to

suture the social, political, and philosophical divisions that are characteristic of our contemporary condition.

Conclusion: Toward a New “Critical” Shift

The debate between the early (1980) and the later (1990) theories of Michael Calvin McGee has been largely ignored by rhetorical theorists or, when acknowledged, not fully staged. McGee’s (1990) appropriation of Lyotard’s (1984) diagnosis of cultural fragmentation created serious tension with his earlier pretensions (1980) to understand the reproduction of the modes of production through ideographs. Instead, discourse fragments are to be the building blocks of textual construction by critics. The rhetoric of equality in Peter Singer’s *Animal Liberation* (2002) provides a topic of conversation between the two theories. Although the three structural relationships (source, culture, and influence) offered by McGee (1990) provide a sophisticated map of the connections between fragments, they do not provide an adequate account of why certain types of rhetorical appeals are used and the motive for attempting to persuade others. Supplementing the postmodern McGee (1990) with a theory of motive grounded in the desire to recompose a social unity from division (Bhabha, 1994; Biesecker, 2002) corrects this oversight. Shifting away from belief in ideology as confirmation of social control, the “ideographic fragment” as a concept of scholarly investigation responds to the fragmentation of culture. It makes an appeal to an impossible, illusory social cohesion, yet it has relative degrees of influence within many different vernacular publics (Hauser, 1999). Finally, for those interested in Singer’s defense of non-human animals, the “ideographic fragment” provides a conceptual tool to map the sources, cultural responsiveness, and reception of his equality principle while also enabling an account of his motive for his rhetorical appeal.

This investigation has sought to use debate as a framing metaphor for exploring a tension within rhetorical

theory. Working under the assumption that each side of an issue should be given voice and its arguments treated with respect, the fruit of this staged conflict is the development of a new theoretical concept: the “ideographic fragment.” The “ideographic fragment” permutes McGee’s later theory of fragments (1990) with an explanation of rhetorical motive and rhetorical circulation that can account for why certain fragments, usually high-level value abstractions, still offer, at least in the case of equality, a viable appeal to several different interested publics in a culture. If this theoretical intervention is correct, then future research needs to go back through previous scholarship on ideographs, determining whether the results herein are applicable to other forms of value appeals. In addition, this research ought to spur future scholars to bring the study of ideographs into the ongoing call to investigate vernacular discourse (Ono & Sloop, 1995). Finally, this essay ought to alert scholars to the benefit of thinking through the McGee debate as a scene of theoretical innovation. The tensions between scholarly positions can become, if treated fully and fairly, the foundations for new forms of theoretical synthesis.

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